

to ward off terror incidents. While the two sides have decided to have more meetings of their foreign secretaries, the two foreign ministers would meet in New York in September to review the progress of the dialogue.

The meeting happened amid a great deal of strain in the relationship, coming close after Manmohan had a candid conversation with Pakistan President Asif Ali Zardari when he met him in Russia last month where he ticked him off publicly about not doing anything on stemming terrorism. The dialogue was also fuelled by pressure from international interlocutors like

logue provides a much needed boost in his bid to ensure that the civilian regime in Pakistan is in control.

While New Delhi insisted that there should be a new template for talks, it is not willing to get back to business as usual till its concerns on terrorism are met. Pakistan did rake up the K-word, with Gilani linking the resolution of the Kashmir dispute to peace in South Asia. That is also one of the reasons why Pakistan is insisting on the resumption of the composite dialogue that deals with eight subjects, including peace and security and Kashmir. Pakistan also

an accused in the 26/11 Mumbai attacks for masterminding the attacks.

There is little to suggest that Pakistan has acted on dismantling terrorism infrastructure, as till May this year there were 185 incidents of infiltration reported from Pakistan. Recently, a secret report sent to South Block also said that the Pakistan Army was using helicopters to retrieve the bodies of hundreds of militants on the Line of Control. Reports suggest that seven dead bodies were lifted by the Pakistan Army helicopters last week. These, sources say, are the militants who died in extreme

AP



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HARD ROAD AHEAD

- **26/11 ATTACKS:** Pakistan assures India that it would take significant steps to bring Mumbai attack perpetrators to justice.
- **Problem:** Progress has been tardy including inability to act against LeT chief Hafiz Mohammad Saeed and other terror leaders.
- **Intelligence Cooperation:** Agree to share real-time and actionable intelligence to prevent terror attacks.
- **Problem:** When India shared intelligence, Pakistan used it to wipe out evidence.
- **Composite Dialogue:** Agree that terrorism and dialogue should not be bracketed.
- **Problem:** Pakistan may raise the alleged involvement of India in Baluchistan.

the US who were pressing India to sit down with Pakistan at the dialogue table. Even though the security establishment had warned against moving forward on talks with Pakistan, the opinion of the Foreign Office prevailed. It felt that the diplomatic gains India had made in the aftermath of 26/11 terrorist attack could be neutralised as the focus could shift away from terrorism to putting pressure on India. With Pakistan taking action against the Taliban groups in Swat, the international support that had eroded earlier was now turning into sympathy, so India had to reassess its options. For Gilani, restarting the dia-

pressed the issue of expediting the probe into the Samjhauta Express attacks, which it claims were carried out by Hindu fundamentalists. Pakistan also brought in the question of alleged Indian involvement in its strife-torn Baluchistan province.

During the talks, India also sought clarity on the Pakistani stand over the release of Lashkar-e-Toiba (LeT) leader Hafiz Mohammad Saeed and the withdrawal of petitions challenging his release from the Supreme Court. While Pakistan clarified that it was following legal procedure in the case of Saeed, New Delhi is not convinced as Saeed has been named as

weather conditions while trying to mount a Kargil-style operation in March this year.

While the dialogue needs to be given a second chance, it would be foolhardy for India to jump into restarting the composite dialogue process without assessing action on the ground on the issue of terrorism. On a parallel track, the Government should work to secure its borders and prevent terror attacks in the future. India should draw timelines in its talks with Pakistan and insist that it will not be business as usual with Pakistan till it meets its commitments to dismantle the terror infrastructure. ■